ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Hedging and stance

Hedging is not constant doubt. It is the disciplined match between the strength of a claim and the quality, quantity and limits of its evidence.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Calibrate certainty and communicate a responsible stance.

Adjust the strength of a claim with modals, adverbs, reporting verbs and impersonal patterns without making the message vague.

MODEL

The findings appear to suggest a modest improvement.

modal/adverb/reporting verb + precise, calibrated claim

6 GUIDED STAGES · 29 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Distinguish observation, probability and cautious inference.

OUTCOME 2

02

Select stance devices that match the evidence.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid both overstatement and empty vagueness.

Build meaning before form

Adjust the strength of a claim with modals, adverbs, reporting verbs and impersonal patterns without making the message vague.

Certainty should follow the evidence

A small pilot study may suggest a pattern; several consistent controlled trials may strongly indicate it. The reporting verb and modal communicate both the result and the confidence it deserves.

Good stance is therefore an evidence decision before it is a vocabulary decision.

A practical scale of commitment

May and might keep a possibility open. Is likely to expresses a reasoned probability. Appears to separates observable indications from firm confirmation. Demonstrates commits the writer much more strongly.

The scale is contextual: even a strong-looking verb can be inappropriate when the sample, method or source is weak.

Evidence position	Possible wording
limited indication	may suggest
reasonable probability	is likely to
consistent support	strongly indicates

Precision before timidity

A careful claim still states who observed what, under which conditions and with what limitation. Responsible hedging increases precision; it does not replace content.

Compare This might possibly help somehow with The intervention may reduce waiting time in small clinics. The second is cautious and informative.

Reader relationship and stance

Stance also shapes the relationship with readers. It can leave room for alternative interpretations, distinguish fact from inference and prevent disagreement from sounding dismissive.

Use boosters only when the evidence warrants them, and use hedges where uncertainty is genuinely relevant.

Reason through the pattern

The scale connects evidence strength to claim strength. The aim is not to move every statement towards caution, but to place each one at the defensible point.

01	02
modal/adverb/reporting verb	precise, calibrated claim

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Keep the proposition concrete, testable and appropriately limited.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Strength	Typical resources	Example
strong	clearly, demonstrates	The data clearly demonstrate...
moderate	likely, appears to	The change is likely to...
cautious	may, tends to, suggests	The evidence may suggest...

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

may suggest	limited evidence
is likely to	reasonable probability
strongly indicates	consistent evidence

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Stacking may, possibly and perhaps.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using proves when the evidence only suggests.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Weakening a sentence until it no longer makes a meaningful claim.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

A small pilot study ___ that the method may help.

OPTIONS suggests · proves · guarantees · confirms beyond doubt

A2 · CONTEXT 2

Demand is ___ to remain stable next quarter.

OPTIONS likely · proved · certainly maybe · tending that

A3 · CONTEXT 3

The pattern ___ to be temporary.

OPTIONS appears · proves · must certainly · is seeming that

A4 · CONTEXT 4

These results ___ not apply to every age group.

OPTIONS may · prove · are certain · demonstrate to

A5 · CONTEXT 5

Remote workers ___ report higher autonomy.

OPTIONS tend to · must always · prove to · are guaranteed to

A6 · CONTEXT 6

Multiple trials ___ indicate a consistent effect.

OPTIONS strongly · possibly perhaps · weakly may · seem maybe to

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

The decline _____ to be slowing, but it _____ continue for another month.

OPTIONS Gap 1: appears / proves / guarantees · Gap 2: may / proves / certainly maybe

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

The responses _____ that users value speed; however, the sample _____ be representative.

OPTIONS Gap 1: suggest / prove / guarantee · Gap 2: may not / must not always / proves not

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

The evidence _____ supports the first claim, while the second _____ less certain.

OPTIONS Gap 1: strongly / perhaps may / tends to maybe · Gap 2: appears / proves / demonstrates

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

The initial findings _____ that shorter meetings improve focus. The effect _____ to be stronger in small teams, although it _____ depend on task type. Participants _____ to report less fatigue. Because the sample was limited, the results _____ be interpreted cautiously.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

appears · guarantee · guaranteed · is certain · may · prove · prove to · proved · proves · should · suggest · tended · will certainly

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

This study proves the policy works. -> This study _____ the policy may work. All users prefer the new design. -> Users _____ prefer the new design. The change will increase sales. -> The change _____ increase sales. The explanation is correct. -> The explanation _____ correct. The effect applies everywhere. -> The effect _____ apply in every context.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Hedge this claim: The intervention solves the problem.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Write an original Hedging and stance response for context 2. Include likely to remain.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Write an original Hedging and stance response for context 3. Include may not, might not.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Write an original Hedging and stance response for context 4. Include may affect.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Hedging and stance response for context 1. Include suggest, may.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Hedging and stance response for context 2. Include clearly, may.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Hedging and stance response for context 3. Include tend to.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: certainty.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: evidence.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: modal.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: reporting verb.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

suggests

Use “suggests”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

A2

likely

Use “likely”. Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

A3

appears

Use “appears”. Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers.

A4

may

Use “may”. Keep the proposition concrete, testable and appropriately limited.

A5

tend to

Use “tend to”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

A6

strongly

Use “strongly”. Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

appears / may

Use “appears”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence. Use “may”. Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

B2

suggest / may not

Use “suggest”. Decide how much commitment the claim can support. Use “may not”. Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers.

B3

strongly / appears

Use “strongly”. Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers. Use “appears”. Keep the proposition concrete, testable and appropriately limited.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

suggest

Use “suggest”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

C2

appears

Use “appears”. Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

C3

may

Use “may”. Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers.

C4

tended

Use “tended”. Keep the proposition concrete, testable and appropriately limited.

C5

should

Use “should”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

suggests that

Use “suggests that”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

D2

tend to

Use “tend to”. Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

D3

is likely to

Use “is likely to”. Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers.

D4

appears to be

Use “appears to be”. Keep the proposition concrete, testable and appropriately limited.

D5

may not

Use “may not”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The intervention appears to reduce the problem.

Use “The intervention appears to reduce the problem.”. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

E2

Prices are likely to remain stable.

Use “Prices are likely to remain stable.”. Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

E3

The results may not be generalisable.

Use “The results may not be generalisable.”. Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers.

E4

This may affect demand.

Use “This may affect demand.”. Keep the proposition concrete, testable and appropriately limited.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The data suggest a modest improvement, although the small sample may limit generalisation.

The model combines accurate Hedging and stance with a clear purpose. Assess the quality and scope of the evidence.

F2

The data clearly show a decline in May; they may also suggest a longer-term trend.

The model combines accurate Hedging and stance with a clear purpose. Decide how much commitment the claim can support.

F3

Users tend to prefer the new design; tend to is appropriate because the survey was not universal.

The model combines accurate Hedging and stance with a clear purpose. Choose one purposeful hedge instead of stacking several weak markers.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____